

Lightweight OS to run virtual machines on?

Asked 12 years ago Modified 10 years, 10 months ago Viewed 4k times

▲
2 It's always complex to install multiple OSs on a machine, but it's easy to use VirtualBox (or similar). But running VirtualBox on a full OS and then running different OSs from there seems a little heavy and unnecessary sometimes.

▼ Is there any simple OS for which the only task is to be a host to easily run and manage virtual OSs on? Something that's not too advanced?



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edited Feb 25, 2014 at 9:03



karel

13.8k

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asked Feb 25, 2014 at 8:31



Lars C. Magnusson

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1 Answer

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▲
6 If there are no requirements other than virtualization, a so-called "bare-metal" hypervisor is a possible solution. They come with the minimal suite of software required to access network and storage and provide a basic console interface. The actual configuration and management is done remotely with a client or web interface.

▼ The most widely known bare-metal hypervisors are:



- VMware ESXi
- Citrix XenServer
- The Xen Open Source Project (upon which XenServer is built)

They are all free, but offer varying hardware support. The most important thing to note is that Software RAID *will not* be supported, ever. This includes motherboards' FakeRAID.

I've had the best performance using ESXi, on a regular machine.

Update I forgot Hyper-V Server, naturally. It's also free (and probably supports software RAID), but I've had absolutely no luck getting the remote management tools to work. If you don't have

Active Directory, I definitely advise you not to use Hyper-V Server. I also think Hyper-V is terrible in general, but that's just my opinion.

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edited Feb 25, 2014 at 8:56

answered Feb 25, 2014 at 8:43



user219095

66.2k

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There is also (the free) Hyper-V server as well. However it is ill-suited for desktop virtualization as it doesn't offer hardware passthrough. – Dai Feb 25, 2014 at 8:53

Right you are. Answer updated. Still, everything I mentioned isn't for desktop virtualization (as in virtualization on desktop/workstation machines). – user219095 Feb 25, 2014 at 8:57

Is this software meant for servers only? Or could this be installed in my PC? – Lars C. Magnusson Feb 25, 2014 at 12:34

There's nothing special about "servers". They're basically just PCs with extended support. They're sometimes also required when you need support (as in support contract with the vendor) for installed software. – user219095 Feb 25, 2014 at 12:39

Ok I thought servers sometimes had different processors but I guess not :) – Lars C. Magnusson Feb 25, 2014 at 20:37

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